



6 HACKING

The importance of having unique passwords for each service that you sign up for was made all the more clearer last year. Forbes, Kickstarter, Adobe, Target, University of Maryland, LinkedIn, eHarmony, Last.fm, Twitter etc. are just some of the companies that got hacked and have confirmed data theft. If you've had an account on any of these sites then you need to change your password.

While hacking incidents targeting individuals are numerous (even the website of Nepal's President was hacked) many of the victims pointed the finger at chinese hackers. A security company called Mandiant released a report highlighting a Unit 61398 of the People's Liberation Army. Turns out it's a Cyber Warfare department of the military which has been accused for targeting government offices worldwide other than mainstream companies. You can check out the Lastpass website to figure out if your account was compromised.



7 PATENT TROLLING

One fine day you'll get a cease and desist letter mentioning a few vague technological terms. It so turns out that some little element in your company's product "infringes" a patent held by the complainant. You can either fight the patent in court or pay a moderate fee to settle out of court, often priced such that it seems to be the better option. Congratulations! You've encountered your first patent troll. Something as small as having a rounded rectangle design (patented by Apple) could entail a lawsuit from firms whose sole objective is to collect patents on the cheap (often from bankrupt firms) and then sue everyone on the planet.

8 PLANNED OBSOLESCENCE

A commonly accepted practice when it comes to manufacturing is that of planned obsolescence.

When a product is made it is designed to fail after a certain period of time. The printer industry is one of the prominent culprits. Most printers have a page counter inside which counts the number of prints that has been printed since it rolled off the assembly line. Another way is to have circuits which prevent the ink cartridges from being used for a longer time. If that wasn't enough then the printer uses all colour ink cartridges for printing black and white content, despite having a black cartridge separately.

Even Apple does it but under the guise of "a brilliant design" which has the battery sealed inside the body and the only way it can be replaced is by sending it back to Apple for a hefty price. Even in electronic devices components that are sensitive to heat are often placed right next to a heat source.



9 CONSOLE CONTROVERSY

The eighth generation consoles had their own share of controversies with Microsoft's XBOX One taking the cake. Months ahead of launch Microsoft announced it's always on feature

which meant that the console would pay attention for visual and audio cues 24x7 since gesture was part of the user experience. Critics on twitter were told to "deal with it" by a Microsoft employee who soon "quit on his own accord". Then hardware issues were rampant, this included a grinding noise that many owners experienced. Lastly, swearing while using Upload Studio could get you banned from Xbox Live.

The Playstation4 wasn't bereft of its share of controversies. Due to the poor treatment of employees at Foxconn (they made the PS4) certain employees started sabotaging units on the production line. This resulted in the blue light of death error for units. A video streaming feature on the PS4 was stopped after certain users started uploading mature/nonsensical content.

10 BITCOINS

Bitcoin has been riding a wild roller coaster ride with the exchange rates reaching ridiculous heights and then plummeting down

to unknown depths. However, this isn't the controversial part. Given the anonymity the currency became favoured by a lot of illegal elements and thus the entire infrastructure around the cryptocurrency came into the crosshairs of the law.

One controversial incident was when a certain group of miners came together under a single pool and started mining. What started out as a common practice of getting coins faster became controversial when the cumulative computational power of this group neared 50% of the overall bitcoin computation in the world, this meant that the group alone could ratify or for that matter reject transactions on a whim, thus, giving them control over every transaction that would have taken place in the bitcoin network, thankfully they stopped and enforced rules to prevent breaking the 51% barrier.

A rather recent problem that cropped up is that of transaction malleability. Bitcoin transactions are one way only and requires a confirmation to mark a transaction as complete. One hacker managed to trick the system and make it seem as if a transaction did not take place at all, this caused the system to repeat the transaction over and over. However, money was still getting transferred and the hacker made away with \$2.7 million!

